



TESTING TIMES



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Kavita Menon

kavita.menon@thehindu.co.in

Pre-season testing offers a glimpse into the new season, yet it rarely reveals the full picture. While lap times and mileage offer clues, teams use this period to experiment rather than push their cars to the limit. The three-day testing is for refinement, setups and gathering mountains of data under varying conditions. As the engines roared at the Bahrain International Circuit at the end of February, one thing became clear — this could be the closest F1 season in years.

Given that F1 is entering its fourth season under the current ground-effect regulations, reliability was expected to be high — and that's exactly what was seen. This year's testing suggested a tighter fight at the front among McLaren, Ferrari, Red Bull and Mercedes, with the defending constructors' champion just edging ahead.

'Front'runners

McLaren appeared to have the most complete package, with both Lando Norris and Oscar Piastri confident in the cars' performance. The car was consistently quick, and if their testing form translates into race pace, McLaren could be the team to beat.

All eyes were understandably on car no. 44 of Lewis Hamilton, who took the scarlet red Ferrari out on track. Though it faced some technical issues on the final day, Charles Leclerc will hope to maximise its potential early in the season, while Hamilton settles into his new environment.

Red Bull, however, had a mixed test. While it was third in qualifying and simulations, early indications suggested that it might not be at striking distance of McLaren and Ferrari, but under threat from an improved Mercedes.

The most active team in mileage (458 laps), Mercedes looked like it had put behind the unpredictability element that haunted it last year.

George Russell and Kimi Antonelli hit the ground running, and the car appears to have given the team optimism for the season ahead.

Midfield melee

A handful of teams are expected to be right on the tail of the grid leaders, meaning more competition for the point-scoring positions. Among the midfielders who seemed to have made the most progress is a certain Williams.

The nine-time constructors' champion team, which now has Carlos Sainz behind the wheel alongside Alexander Albon, showed promising signs and could be in a tussle with Alpine for the 'best of the rest' spot.

Aston Martin, once on the prowl for podium finishes, looks to have dropped down the order, finding itself among Haas and Racing Bulls. Fernando Alonso admitted that the car has slid from the front of the midfield, and expects a tough challenge for AM to maintain its